The Impossible Engine explained

Has NASA really discovered a fuel-free thrust technology for space travel?

Samir Alam
readersletters@digit.in

It would seem that NASA broke physics this year. In a paper released on 28 July 2014, titled 'Anomalous Thrust Production from an RF Test Device Measured on a Low-Thrust Torsion Pendulum', scientists at NASA quietly dropped a bomb on the physics world. It followed up the release of the research paper with a presentation at the 50th Joint Propulsion Conference two days later, which further excited the scientific community. And in some cases, even led to the drawing of battle lines concerning the implications of NASA's research for humanity. So what was this paper all about? Well, it's quite simple really – the potential for fuel-free space travel. Ain't that a kick in the head?

Anomalous sounds dodgy

Space travel has always been a tricky venture. Ever since the first probes and rockets were sent out by the Soviet Union, we've witnessed the unchanging nature of the basic technology. Escaping gravity costs us, a lot. And most of that cost is rooted in the propulsion required to break free of the Earth's pull and set us free in space. The only means to achieve such power is through the burning of fuel, which poses the core problem. Even though rocket fuel technology has developed over the last 60 years, it hasn't changed all that much. Even with the reusable Space Shuttle, the fuel-to-vessel ratio is 30:1, which means that in order to thrust 1 kilogram of mass out of Earth's gravity, we require 20 kilograms of fuel, which is already weighing down the craft at the time of lift off. The expense is just too high for space travel to be an affordable pursuit.